

The dawn of democracy: a critique the theory of democracy

Veith Selk

Veith Selk's book "Demokratiedämmerung" (Twilight of Democracy) radically the supposed superiority of democratic systems. Selk argues that democracy today neither legitimises nor solves problems, but must be viewed with increasing scepticism. Democratic legitimisation is perceived as insufficient, particularly in the face of global challenges such as climate change and an increasingly complex society. This leads to a growing acceptance of expertocratic solutions that can supposedly deal with highly complex problems more efficiently. The liberal idea of progressive democratisation is thus rejected as increasingly unrealistic.

According to Selk, democracy is suffering above all from increasing politicisation, with a simultaneous decline in the ability to reach consensus on fundamental values and rules. Political fields are becoming increasingly diverse, but at the same time less comprehensible for the general population. This violates the Sartori criterion, according to which democracy only works if it remains comprehensible to the average citizen. The promise of an informed citizenry is undermined by increasing knowledge asymmetries and the emergence of heterogeneous identity groups. This erodes the democratic sense of community and leads to increasing socio-economic polarisation.

Democracy is currently undergoing a process of devolution that encompasses four key developments. Firstly, intensive politicisation is leading to excessive demands being placed on democracy and to legitimacy problems. Secondly, the differentiation of political issues creates a lack of clarity, which makes democratic control more difficult. Thirdly, political competence is distributed unequally, which places an additional burden on democratic processes. Fourthly, the end of democratic capitalism would mean a loss of socio-economic stability and cohesion.

Social inequality is particularly evident in the selective nature of political participation, which primarily favours socio-economically privileged groups. Selk notes that despite increasing formal opportunities for participation, these do not lead to more equality. Instead, participatory governance promotes power asymmetries by de facto reserving opportunities for influence to those who are better off in society.

Democratic processes therefore appear increasingly unfair and insufficient to guarantee genuine political equality. The hope for more democracy through increased participation is therefore proving to be an illusion.

In the context of this development, three dominant post-democratic approaches emerged: Right-wing populism, expertocracy and participatory governance. Right-wing populism promises a return to a simplified and homogenised social order. Expertocracy, on the other hand, represents a supposedly fact-oriented, low-political decision-making process legitimised by scientific expertise. Participatory governance, on the other hand, suggests democratisation through citizen participation, but in reality leads to political selectivity. These forms respond to the deficits of democratic politics without actually solving their essential problems.

Selk emphasises that democracy appears increasingly opaque and ineffective. Decisions are not made in a comprehensible manner and their responsibilities are unclear, which fosters mistrust and political alienation. Institutional promises made by democratic governments are losing their credibility because political processes are fragmented and polycentric in structure. The confusing political reality renders democracy epistemically and practically ineffective. As a result, democracy is gradually losing its actual basis of legitimacy.

According to Selk, analysing the end of democratic capitalism shows that democracy and capitalism were historically linked and enabled relative prosperity for broad sections of the population. However, with the erosion of this connection, socio-economic inequality is growing dramatically. The middle class is shrinking, while oligarchic structures are establishing themselves, dominated by a super-rich elite. In the long term, this development would lead to a neo-feudal society in which democratic principles would become increasingly irrelevant. As a result, democratic regimes are losing stability and legitimacy.

At the same time, Selk criticises the fact that globalisation and capitalism systematically restrict the scope for political action. Political power is increasingly being shifted to transnational and private structures, causing nation states to lose their ability to control. This makes democratic self-legislation structurally more difficult and almost impossible in the long term. Democracy is becoming an empty façade behind which political decisions can hardly be influenced by the citizenry. This makes democracy less and less credible as a form of legitimisation.

The crisis of democracy is also becoming increasingly apparent in theory, as democratic theory can no longer adequately solve its problems. Selk describes this as a "paradigm crisis", in which explanations of democratic theory are becoming increasingly complicated without providing actual solutions. Alternative theories such as post-colonialism are becoming increasingly important in this context, as they fundamentally question Western concepts of democracy. The theoretical foundations of democratic theory are now so weakened that they are hardly convincing. A theoretical revitalisation of democracy therefore seems unlikely.

Overall, Selk paints a bleak picture of the future of democracy. The process of devolution is not simply a setback, but the expression of a

deeper structural crisis. He no longer describes democracy as a progressive modernisation project, but as a transient political order that is increasingly losing legitimacy and relevance. Democratic principles such as equality, a focus on the common good and political transparency are being systematically undermined. A return or revitalisation of democracy seems unrealistic under the current conditions.

Excerpts from the book

Location: 417

11The narrative of the unchallenged normative preferability of democracy, the best possible legitimisation by means of democratic procedures, the problem-solving ability of democratic regimes and the emergence of flexible, adaptable and creative political subjects has thus become questionable. This results in an overall scepticism towards democracy.

Location: 505

Ecologically promote the increasing awareness of ecological issues in the "Desolation Anthropocene"[35] and the global problem of anthropogenic climate change, the devaluation of democratic legitimisation and policy-making. These are described as under-complex and inadequate to the problem. Promoted by the increase in political complexity and the assertion of the need for specialist expertise in policy fields that appear increasingly complicated, this leads to the expansion of expertocratic forms of legitimisation and governance being proposed in social science with a view to Western democracies.

Location: 606

Democratic princely rule combines strong leadership legitimised by media spectacles with authoritarian risk management, which appears to have no alternative due to a hyper-globalisation that has become politically uncontrollable and high social complexity, as it is better suited to modern challenges.

Location: 621

The liberal-democratic progression thesis is implausible because it no longer corresponds to the changed socio-political conditions.

Location: 643

More and more issues have to be decided politically, although there is less and less agreement on the legitimacy standards, objectives and rules of the debate.

Location: 645

Politics becomes so confusing that it the Sartori criterion[66], according to which politics in a democracy must also be able to be understood by non-experts. The criterion, named by Greven after the Italian political scientist Giovanni Sartori, states that democracy is the most complicated of all political regimes, but that it can only exist if its principles, institutions and processes are understood by the average citizen.

Location: 652

In the context of increasing differentiation, complexity and inequality of political knowledge, the democratic theory assumption that the lack of understanding can be remedied through civic competence and educational ability is refuted. In reality, knowledge is becoming increasingly unevenly distributed, political disparities of influence are growing and heterogeneous communities of knowledge and identity are emerging. Finally, democratic capitalism was a historical institution of compromise that ensured a relative equalisation of living conditions and future opportunities. Its dissolution leads to socio-economic polarisation and dries up the sources of social cohesion.

Note | Location: 656 Location: 661

Empirically, it follows from the process of devolution that post-democratic political approaches are emerging in the form of right-wing populism, expertocracy and participatory governance, which respond to the deficits of democratic politics. Although they partly invoke the idea of democracy, in reality they embody undemocratic approaches to problem-solving and legitimisation.

Location: 671

Democratic politics appears epistemically opaque and practically ineffective, it is confronted with accusations of institutional hypocrisy and its democratisation of speech appears structurally blocked.

Location: 674

Overall, politics appears confusing, uncontrolled and opaque due to its fragmented and polycentric structure. This damages the credibility of the normative promises attributed to the institutions.

Location: 733

no prospect of a revitalisation of the democratic paradigm, neither in political practice nor in academic theory, as the

devolution, the democratic idea of legitimisation cannot be reconciled with a realistic analysis of reality.

Location: 756

The devolution of democracy is the result of four empirically interrelated but analytically distinct processes: Firstly, intensified politicisation, which creates legitimacy problems due to the lack of socially broad inclusion in the decision-making process and the spillover of politicisation to democracy itself; secondly, the increase in differentiation and complexity, which makes political life in democratic regimes opaque, corrodes the democratic sense of community and dissolves the civic we-identity; thirdly, the growing cognitive asymmetry within the citizenry, which leads to differences in political information and relevant knowledge that are incompatible with the democratic public spirit; and fourthly, finally, the deepening of socio-political inequality in the context of the end of democratic capitalism as a central political-economic institution of pacification, which contributed to the stability and attractiveness of democratic regimes in the second half of the 20th century. The second half of the 20th century led to the stability and attractiveness of democratic regimes.

Location: 777

Participation research now recognises that participation is, by and large, socially selective. It favours the socio-economically and educationally better off.[3] The participatory governance that has emerged should not be confused with participatory democracy.

Location: 793

In a political society, not everything is political at the same time, but everything can be politicised. The concept of political society is based on the fact that there is no longer any social sphere or issue that is protected from politicisation in principle.

Location: 835

Even where a "neoliberal" privatisation policy was implemented, a space free of the state, administration and politics was not established; instead, state rule, public resources and bureaucratic administration were used for particular purposes.

Location: 854

In democracies, therefore, political rule is legitimised not only by democratic procedures and the input legitimisation they generate, but also by the promise of instrumental rationality in the conduct of public affairs and the achievement of abstract and concrete goals (for example

example, sustainability and low petrol prices). Democratic politics is also based on output legitimacy.

Location: 867

The politicisation of procedures can lead to a structural lack of legitimacy for elected officials. This process is already well advanced in the political system of the United States.

Location: 877

Overall, the politicisation dynamic within democratic regimes is increasing, while their ability to generate the legitimacy required for the increase in political decisions is decreasing.

Location: 920

41 An increasingly complex society generates increasingly complex policies and vice versa.[28] One sign of the increase in political differentiation and complexity is the increase in policy fields. This goes hand in hand with a decrease in the ability to implement and control policy.

Location: 939

The increasingly differentiated network structure of politics corrodes the public spirit, increases complexity, makes coherent governance more difficult and makes it risky for parties to formulate clear programmatic alternatives in election campaigns. Many momentous decisions and non-decisions can therefore not be attributed by the citizenry to democratic decision-making processes, party political programmes and the actions of representatives. Against the background of this experience, the standard model of electoral democracy, according to which parties run with programmes for which they collect support and, in the event of their participation in government, have to assume responsibility after a legislative period, seems unrealistic.

Location: 1,074

The result is the fraying and multiplication of informal practices of power diplomacy that circumvent the democratic formation of opinion and will and undermine the democratic procedures that artificially create political equality. Complex polycentric networks of power are replacing the place and the imagined collective subject of power of a community in the sense of the idea of a citizenry that legislates for itself by means of its representatives in a political space.

Location: 1,094

Democracy requires political cognitive symmetry within the citizenry. This is true from the perspective of normatively demanding theories of democracy, which require a

mutual understanding and the ability to engage in "fact-based" argumentation; however, this also applies if a minimalist model of democracy is taken as a basis. This is because even normatively economical theories of democracy assume that citizens in democratic regimes can judge governments in the light of their performance and decisions, hold them accountable and rationally punish or confirm them at the next election. This presupposes that citizens know, or at least believe they know, who decided what and with what consequences, what the political alternatives were and how the decisions taken affect their own interests, identities and concerns.

Location: 1,157

Against this background, Brian Leiter rightly speaks of a crisis of epistemic authority.[58] Due to this change in political communication on a factual, thematic and audience-related level, public opinion, as it is constructed in the leading media of the political elite, can no longer fulfil its assigned function of rationalising, condensing and representing socially relevant political opinions and providing general knowledge.

Location: 1,172

These coherent ideologies have disintegrated. They have been replaced by a confusing struggle for interpretative power that selectively takes into account the fragmentary, episodic and heterogeneous knowledge within the citizenry, but does not give it an ideological form. The resulting polyphony of political discourse is heightened by the digital media revolution and the crisis of epistemic authority.

Location: 1,372

In a functioning democracy, it is decided politically what may and may not become a commodity. At the same time, despite all the variations between more liberal and more coordinated capitalisms and across the epochs of capitalist economic activity, the core capitalist institutions remain intact in democratic regimes: the commodification of labour, the profit orientation of the private economy, the ethical legitimization of private welfare within the framework of professional ethics and the institution of private business.

Location: 1,419

The unemployment and weak growth caused by the business class must be blamed on the political class; in democratic capitalism, this class assumes a "scapegoat function".[102] This constellation leads to the business class occupying a politically privileged position in capitalist democracies as a result of the market socialisation and ownership structure. It has an indirect but powerful potential for sanctions, the use of which the political class fears and therefore

anticipated. In this way, the capitalist market acts as an "automatic punishment mechanism"[103] that structurally limits the scope for democratic reform. In democratic capitalism, pluralism has limits and favours the business class.

Location: 1,444

Democratic capitalism", according to Kotkin, "brought broadly shared prosperity." [108] For him, this development is primarily linked to the emergence of a middle class supporting liberal democracy. However, as he wants to show using the example of the USA, this era is now coming to an end, as there has been a meltdown of the middle class in socio-structurally relevant respects since the 1980s and a polarisation in terms of social space, education, mentality, income and wealth between a benefiting minority and a losing majority. According to Kotkin, the unprecedented improvement in general living conditions as a result of the link between democracy and capitalism is under threat: "This remarkable social advancement, the great achievement of liberal capitalism, is now clearly jeopardised, and with it the future of democracy." [109]

Location: 1,453

However, Kotkin does not only associate the end of democratic capitalism with an increase in socio-economic divisions and a threat to democracy. Rather, as a result of the disappearance of the middle class, a neo-feudal class society with an oligarchic ruling class of the super-rich at the top would emerge, the outlines of which are already recognisable. Below this top, Kotkin establishes a class of well-educated, technically savvy intelligentsia and service and entrepreneurial elite. The broad base - the third estate - of this neo-feudal social structure is formed by the lowered sections of the middle classes and the lower classes, for whom left-wing and right-wing populism in particular represents a political defence and delaying strategy that will not be able to stop the development of neo-feudal structures in the long term, but rather only represents an indicator of the decline of democracy.

Location: 1,547

The democracies have equipped mobile capital with a considerable amount of exit power through their national debt and a policy of removing borders, thereby increasing its potential for blackmail. The European market structure, firmly anchored through constitutionalisation, has become a "prison", as Lindblom put it with regard to the political effect of market structures.

Location: 1,566

In this context, the reference to the supposed practical constraints of globalisation became a rhetorical figure of contingency absorption and

137] More recently, however, it no longer holds water, because the liberal model of globalised capitalism has been politicised.

Location: 1,588

The emerging BRICS countries[141] have an economic style that deviates from the liberal paradigm of the "Washington Consensus". Family networks, protectionism, authoritarian labour relations and the fusion of state and capital form a combination that reveals the outlines of a new type of anti-liberal capitalism.

Location: 1,613

In other words, democracy is no longer a project of progress that may be subject to many dangers and setbacks, but is in principle complementary to modernisation. What is described in the literature on democratic theory as a temporary setback or as a contingent danger of regression is in reality the consequence of an ongoing development trend.

Location: 1,665

Devolution dimension Transformation trend Politicisation Controversial nature of democracy Differentiation and complexity Uncontrollability of democracy Cognitive asymmetry Incomprehensibility of democracy End of democratic capitalism Injustice of democracy

Location: 1,726

As the experience of the "omnipresence of loss"[157] after the end of democratic capitalism undermines the promise of the common good of democratic regimes and undermines their legitimisation, it is becoming increasingly implausible to describe Western political regimes as democracies. "Ideas are plausible if they are immediately obvious and do not need to be further justified in the communication process." [158] It no longer makes sense to describe political regimes in the way that democratic theory does. They do not appear to be 90orders in which citizens are able to form an open-ended and "equally free" on public affairs and in which the effects of political programmes and decisions benefit all citizens fairly according to their respective achievements, rights or entitlements. Democracy appears unjust.

Location: 1,740

I show that political alternatives to democracy are emerging in response to the devolution process. I am not concerned here with anti-democratic movements and parties that are explicitly directed against democratic regimes. Rather, with populism, expertocracy and participatory governance, I want to focus on political reactions that criticise democracy, but which

1] They are put forward by their representatives with the aim of correcting and improving the liberal-representative form of democracy.

Location: 1,752

Under conditions of devolution, structural barriers prevent the realisation of democracy, and it is impossible to see how these could be overcome in the future. The hope of re-democratisation or even more democracy is proving to be a chimera.

Location: 1,781

Right-wing populism is therefore responding to devolution with the promise of a simplified retro-democracy. This would restore traditional family structures, the ethnic and cultural community, national sovereignty and the constellation of prosperous industrial capitalism.

Location: 1,838

It embodies a powerful departure from the path of politics that describes itself as having no alternative. In this respect, too, populism proves to be a correlate of politicisation, as it embodies structural politics, which for a long time was only weakly represented in the public sphere, while also lending politicisation an affective dimension.[15] It politicises and represents negative emotions such as anger, hatred and indignation, which had long been banned from the public political stage of the representative institutions of liberal democracies, even though they can be entirely appropriate in certain circumstances.

Location: 1,879

Democracies can only bring their remarkable ability to represent difference to bear if they also have a sufficient degree of social cohesion as a result of a certain degree of social homogeneity. This social homogeneity, for its part, is nothing pre-political or even natural, but is to a large extent the artificial result of past homogenisation policies, which relate to the construction of a national culture,[24] but also to the shaping of socio-economic conditions.

Location: 1,887

However, under the conditions of devolutionary change in democratic societies, the hurdles for a homogenisation policy are high. As a result of the radicalisation of claims to self-determination[27] and the growing importance of individualistic norms and identity patterns in political culture[28], duty-bound norms of community reference and collective identities have come under pressure. Strong solidarity and community obligations in particular are weakened as a result.

Location: 1,923

At the same time, as the capacity for control in the political life of democracies dwindles, some citizens gain the impression of a loss of control and a failure of governance. The impression arises that the most pressing problems are being ignored or talked away, that momentous decisions are no longer being made or at least can no longer be clearly attributed - where no one visibly exercises power, no one is responsible - and that there is a lack of clear political leadership. Against this backdrop, the boom in conspiracy theories is understandable.

Location: 1,938

Political answers to public problems are not right because they are simple, but in a democracy, political answers must be easy to understand. Otherwise they cannot be communicated democratically.

Location: 1,991

While liberalisation represents a gain in the eyes of some (and brings them more freedom, money, prestige, opportunities for self-fulfilment and an increase in the importance of the values and ideas they cherish), others fear a corresponding loss. The right-wing populists claim to represent those who consider themselves losers or fear that they will belong to the losers' camp in the future.

Location: 2,002

The harsh reality is that Trump was elected because he tapped into an inexhaustible well of fears, frustrations and legitimate grievances to which the mainstream parties had no convincing answer. European democracies are in a similar predicament[38].

Location: 2,050

In fact, Viktor Orbán's government, which has been in office since 2010, and its institutional reorganisation of the Hungarian polity can probably be considered the most meaningful case for the question of whether the emergence and consolidation of a genuinely populist regime and corresponding government practice can be observed empirically outside the Latin American context.

Location: 2,150

In the context of the expansive politicisation described above, the model of a "technical state" in Schelsky's sense[65] therefore seems like the antiquated utopia of a scientific planned state from the spirit of the thought pattern of the totally administered world.

Location: 2,177

Due to the growing factorial significance of knowledge that cannot be predicted in principle, the course of scientific and technological civilisation resembles less and less a planned realisation. It is more like an evolution, which certainly also proceeds via planned realisations - but in interaction with 118 unpredictable and, in this sense, contingent innovative effects resulting from the practice research and development.

Location: 2,182

Due to the dialectic between scientifically and technologically informed control knowledge and a decentralised dynamic that generates unforeseeable consequences in different local, sectoral and regional contexts, "the need for sectoral, but also regional and local self-organisation" is growing.[73] Direct demands for participation and the increase in self-organisation are the functional correlates of a scientific and technological civilisation that is only planned to a limited extent and developing largely uncontrolled, which does not reduce the area of political decision-making, but rather expands it.

Location: 2,260

The promise of expertocracy is policy without politics - good substantive policy without political dispute.[88] What are the core characteristics of expertocracy? In the literature, for example by Putnam[89] or Centeno,[90] it is described as a mindset that is primarily found among political actors with a scientific and technical education.

Location: 2,324

According to expertocratic ideology, expert knowledge should not merely inform political decision-making, but rather be the moving force behind political action. According to the expertocratic credo, democratic legitimacy must therefore be overlaid or at least supplemented by epistemic legitimacy. Legitimacy is what is defined by scientific experts as reasonable with regard to a problem determined by expertise.

Location: 2,337

Expertocracy thus occupies a middle position between technocracy on the one hand and scientific policy advice on the other. It is less demanding than the utopian idea of technocracy, but goes beyond scientific policy advice. Technocracy is the utopia of an applied engineering science of public affairs. It promises the abolition of politics or its dissolution into administration and social technology. Scientific policy advice, on the other hand, is initially only the "institutionalised delivery of scientific information to political actors" at a general level.

Location: 2,376

As a thin ideology, expertocracy, like populism, must be enriched with political content and programmes or combined with "thick" ideologies such as neoliberalism, conservatism or socialism in order to become politically viable.

Location: 2,467

As a result, the term "governance" is diffuse in terms of content, which is why it has been attested to be an "empty signifier" that obscures power relations, hides the exercise of power and consequently thematises politics one-sidedly in terms of rule generation and problem solving.

Location: 2,514

It is "essential"[116] for participatory governance to the following goals through the direct participation of citizens: 138-an equal distribution of political power; -a fairer distribution of resources; -a decentralisation of the decision-making process; -a transparent exchange of knowledge and information; -the creation of cooperative relationships and dialogues; -the better realisation of 117] Remarkably, one of the most important categories of political science analysis does not appear in Fischer's list: the assertion of interests. This suggests that the assertion of interests plays no role in participatory governance. It is fitting that the political science discourse on governance sometimes uses a peculiarly non-political semantics, in which "coordination" or "management" is usually used instead of "control" or "rule".

Location: 2,556

In his study on the relationship between participation and social status in the developed democracies of Western Europe, the USA, East Asia, Australia and New Zealand, Russel J. Dalton - himself a political advocate of greater participation and academic pioneer of the participatory revolution - comes to the sobering conclusion that the increase in participatory governance has not empirically led to greater social and political equality. Although the opportunities for influence and participation have de jure expanded to an unprecedented extent, this process is de facto characterised by the fundamental problem of the socio-economic participation gap mediated by educational and income inequalities.

Location: 2,584

The hopes for more freedom, equality and solidarity, which were previously associated with the participatory revolution and are currently linked to participatory governance, are not being fulfilled. More participation does not lead to more democracy because it is highly socially selective.[126] The core areas

of rule continue to be shielded from effective democratic participation and the distribution of power within the citizenry remains asymmetrical.

Location: 2,848

In a mass democracy with a largely apolitical population, the epistemic intransparency of politics is unproblematic if the output performance of the system is accepted. In a mass democracy with a politicised population, epistemic transparency is dysfunctional, even if the output performance is accepted.

Location: 2,949

Wolfgang Merkel, for example, diagnoses "that the principle of equality in democracy has been affected by a double oligarchisation". He describes it as "the socio-economically provoked political self-exclusion of the lower classes and the self-liberation of the top 1 per cent [...] of the income hierarchy from the social ties of their property while at the same time maximising their political influence".[162] While political influence and socio-economic gains accumulate at the top, the lower classes tend to say goodbye to political participation.

Location: 2,986

The differentiated organisations, official structures and networks of complex governance develop their own persistence and development dynamics. By means of the emergence of a transnational and supranational faction within the political class as well as in associations and through other actors involved in private-public policy networks, they develop an interest in themselves, in the light of which a subsequent or retroactive democratisation would appear to be a loss of power.

Location: 2,991

Against this background, the reduction of the nation-state's capacity for control and the opportunities for self-legislation is described in the critical political theory literature as a long-term, frozen loss of democracy.[168] James Tully summarises the reasons for this in the form of three "illegitimate"[169] development trends: - The first trend: the development of a global constitutionalism of regulatory regimes that legally secure capitalist globalisation and "overrule national constitutions, forcing them to comply and free the economy from the control of existing nation states".[170] - Second trend: Due to the need for regulation associated with transnational capitalist globalisation, a multifaceted governance network is developing that disperses political power that could be used in the sense of democratic power politics. The "emergence of multi-layered functional forms of governance at local and global level" results in a "decentralisation and decentralisation of power".

Fragmentation of political power and the forms of political community"[171] - Third trend: The trends of capitalist globalisation and the fragmentation and decentralisation of political power have a negative effect on the formation of political opinion and will as well as political decision-making in traditional democratic institutions, because they deprive them of the opportunities for contestation linked to deliberation and formal democratic procedures. The states themselves are by no means disempowered by this, but they become less capable of democratic power politics.

Location: 3,029

Global governance can be designed to be participatory, representative and responsive, but it cannot be organised democratically.

Location: 4,488

A discourse of legitimisation is a set of ideas, images or practices that present a political regime as functioning in the way its rulers claim, and thus support those who exercise power in the regime.[7] A scientific discourse of legitimisation reinforces the values, world views and political concepts of order propagated by political elites. It is "cultural ammunition for political rulers".

Location: 5,212

As a result of the increase in interdependence and increased interconnectedness between political orders, political autonomy and the ability of political communities to influence themselves are eroding; in turn, the growing multiculturalism and social pluralisation in the process of modernisation are deconstructing the identity of the imagined collective subject of democratic citizenship; and thirdly, the separation between equality-based, public, democratic rule and private power based on unequal resources is being lost, because in the form of heterogeneous governance arrangements within and beyond the state, private-public hybrid forms of political rule and rule-making are emerging. As a result of these three processes, the idea of a citizenry that legislates for itself in equal freedom becomes a fictitious, merely normative category. It falls short of political reality.

Location: 5,228

Progressive modernisation does not lead to the stabilisation, expansion or reinvention of democracy, but to its erosion - in practice as well as in theory.

Location: 5,393

Paradigmatic science (Kuhn) and scientific thought collectives (Fleck) have accommodation and defence mechanisms with which they neutralise the threats to their paradigm or style of thinking.

Location: 5,396

Scientific revolutions and the change of a paradigm become possible when "specialised science can no longer avoid the anomalies that undermine the existing tradition of scientific practice".

Location: 5,412

Rosa argues that social science paradigms are abandoned "when the conceptual systems on which they are based are no longer able to adequately capture the meaning of cultural and political phenomena." [40] When "there is deep uncertainty about guiding value ideas and valid cultural meanings", [41] then there is the possibility for a change in social science paradigms. The process of devolution and the discourse on a crisis of democracy currently point to such a search movement.

Location: 5,454

Using a distinction from Fleck's theory, one can say that the theory of democracy has moved from the "epoch of classicism" to an epoch of "complications" [44] have arisen. It no longer succeeds in formulating democratic solutions to the puzzles of democracy. As a result, the "normal problem-solving activity" [45] that the paradigm used to make possible is failing. Democratic theory begins to proliferate, and more and more modifications have to be made, more and more adaptations undertaken and more and more rhetorical evasion and avoidance strategies deployed. The theory finds itself in a paradigm crisis.

Location: 5,488

In the field of theory, the most influential paradigm at present, and at least a potential future challenger, is probably postcolonialism. [51] It is gaining importance in the social sciences and humanities as a whole, not least because it is an academic theory of reflection on the West's loss of political significance and the rise of non-Western regimes of rule. At least in part, postcolonialism is characterised by a negation of paradigmatic assumptions of social and political science. It represents a potentially competitive paradigm because, at least in one branch of postcolonialism, central categories of liberal-democratic thought such as citizenship, popular sovereignty, the rule of law, the public sphere and human rights, together with their authors of reference in the history of ideas, are not treated in an immanently critical manner, but are categorically rejected.

Location: 5,607

Politicisation, differentiation and complexity, asymmetry of cognition and the end of democratic capitalism as dimensions of devolution undermine the

pillars of a political practice that is orientated towards the common good and therefore legitimate. They form breaking points in regimes that describe themselves as democratic, as they lead to controversy (politicisation), uncontrollability (differentiation and complexity), incomprehensibility (cognitive asymmetry) and injustice (end of democratic capitalism). Social hope and democratic politics, essential elements of a strong democracy alongside a credible focus on the common good in politics,[75] are thus made structurally impossible.

Location: 5,626

Despite the problems of justification and plausibility as well as the differences of interpretation regarding the meaning of democracy, the "feeling of solidarity of thought in the service of a supra-personal idea"[76] - the idea of democracy - is still alive within democratic theory and as such has an integrative effect. It is fuelled by the fact that democracy as a normative ideal and legitimising formula of existing political regimes has been devolutionarily damaged, but not completely devalued. Furthermore, the alternatives to democracy in academia and politics have not yet been sufficiently promoted by counter-hegemonic activism to replace the democratic paradigm in the short term.

Location: 5,633

Politicisation, differentiation and increased complexity mean that the probability of aggregation and build-up effects in politics has increased, which cannot be monitored or foreseen from any point of observation. Niklas Luhmann aptly summarised the resulting potential for political surprise: A legal order that cannot actually be struck at any point cannot actually be defended at any point. This also makes observation and judgement more difficult than at the time of the "revolutionary activities" and the rebellious school teachers 318 and students of the Vormärz. The problem is that a multitude of events can aggregate into tendencies that then elude control. None of the political-social movements that have characterised recent decades could have been predicted; they all came about as surprises[77].